

Episode 85: DVD & Blu-Ray Release Commemorative! *Casshern Sins* Colour Design Notes (Final Episode!)

The Web Anime Style editorial department strictly ordered me: "It would be unseemly to spill over into April, so definitely upload and finish '*Casshern Sins* Colour Design Notes' on the regular posting day of March 31st," and it's true that I thought "well, the last one is just 3 episodes so it'll be easy."

But as expected, I struggled tremendously (sweat). As befits the final 3 episodes (laughs).

Actually, I'm supposed to be at a certain anime-related event at Loft Plus One in Shinjuku's Kabukicho today, and the assembly time was said to be 6 PM, but I'm actually still writing at Madhouse (マッドハウス) (heavy sweat).

Hang in there, me! Don't lose, me!

Now then.

Episodes 22, 23, and 24 were ultimately a battle against time. Director Yamauchi properly wrote storyboards for all 3 consecutive episodes, and while he delegated direction to Nakayama-san and Kimura-kun, he decisively handled the final episode himself!

But time passed mercilessly, and we proceeded with animation meetings as soon as storyboards were completed, with art meetings the week before delivery. Art boards were handled by Matsumoto-san, and background work had everyone who had handled individual episodes until then - Koyama-san, Matsuda-san, See Through Studio, Studio Rufus, and Yuki Yukie-san - all participating in battle. Large meetings with everyone, then dividing the work to complete everything in one week - total warfare. The animation staff were the same. The direction team too. And we colour staff also went to total war.

Episode 22: "A Drop Called Eternity"

Script: Kobayashi Yasuko / Storyboard: Yamauchi Shigeyasu / Direction: Nakayama Naomi / Animation Director: Tominaga Mari / Colour Direction: Kohinata Tomoko

Having seized control of "Luna's City," Leda appeared to have gained eternal life through Luna's healing, but further ruin spread across her face. In fury, Leda received more healing, but amazingly half her body transformed into an ugly form. Dio, parting ways with Leda, took the captive Casshern outside the castle and waited endlessly for his body to regenerate. Then he entered the final duel with the revived Casshern.

Episode 22: Leda vs Luna's "battle of women" and Dio vs Casshern's "battle of men."

In this episode, "Luna's healing" appears on screen for the first time. For this series of "healing" scenes, director Nakayama and I had agreed to "create maximum colour performance." We wanted to create colours for "Luna's room" that were realistic but all like image space.

So especially in the second healing scene in the latter half, I changed colouring cut by cut, overlapped backgrounds and cuts to change colours, and added all sorts of dramatic variations.

Luna is great (laughs). That facial expression and performance showing "So Luna was a woman after all!" The exchange with Leda gives me chills every time I watch it!

Meanwhile, Dio's scenes use contrasting "quiet" colouring, carefully and quietly building up colours to match the background art that changes moment by moment over time.

The scenes connecting these two axes, especially the Ringo, Lyuze, and Ouji scenes, are created with suppressed saturation and heavier colours. This was so the key scenes would stand out. It's the same in episode 23.

Episode 23: "Those Who Return"

Script: Kobayashi Yasuko / Storyboard: Yamauchi Shigeyasu / Direction: Kimura Nobukage / Animation Director: Nishii Terumi / Colour Direction: Akimoto Yuki

Dio and Casshern engage in one-on-one mortal combat. Meanwhile, Leda, abandoned in the robot graveyard, heads to Luna for revenge but gets stabbed by Luna's sword. Casshern arrives there. Understanding everything, Leda heads to Dio. And Casshern confronts Luna.

A story where you can see one conclusion point for each character's fate and way of life as they bear their karma. In a sense, episode 23 was probably one "final episode" - that's how I approached making it.

This episode had two key points. One was the scene where Luna and Casshern confront each other and speak.

So that the conversation between the two could properly reach viewers, I deliberately did nothing special colour-wise. I designed it quietly with so-called normal colour usage. Even so, matching the story's tension, I made some difference between the first half (scene 50 in the storyboard) and latter half (scene 52), shifting toward cooler colours, and additionally asked colour direction Akimoto-san to "read the animation and dialogue content of each cut and vary the shadow depth intensity" to create depth in the characters' expressions.

The other point was Dio's final moments.

Dio, who withdrew saying "I won..." after the final blow in his death battle with Casshern. "I want to make his death scene fitting for Dio's end," "Let's show Dio's death beautifully," "Naturally at sunset" - the director, director Kimura, and I all thought so. So for the scene where Leda snuggles close and they both breathe their last, Umakoshi-san did the animation himself, using the opening's "still image" technique.

Both episode 22 and this episode 23 turned out to be screens that made me think "How did we manage to complete this in such a short schedule!" It's probably an absolutely forbidden way of working schedule-wise, but everyone had the tension and teamwork of "This is the final stretch of what we've built up to - let's get through it!"

And finally episode 24. Even higher hurdles awaited there.

Episode 24: "To the Flower That Blooms in Cycles"

Script: Kobayashi Yasuko / Storyboard & Direction: Yamauchi Shigeyasu / Animation Director: Umakoshi Yoshihiko / Colour Direction: Kunioto Kunio

Complete storyboard package 10 days before delivery. Then editing and voice recording, with art meetings the day after episode 23's delivery. Naturally all-hands-on-deck mode. Art staff had just 5 days. Such a wonderfully impossible schedule to begin work.

The world several decades after parting with Luna. Braiking Boss had joined with Luna and revived the empire, but he too continued to doubt this world and Luna. Meanwhile, Ringo, Ouji, Friender, Lyuze, and Casshern were living quietly like a family in a remote place. But ruin progressed, and Ouji, then Lyuze faced death. Dejected Casshern. Eventually resolving himself, Casshern heads toward Luna...

Laugh or cry, this was the end. I handled colour direction for the final episode.

Anyway, with "several decades later...", Braiking Boss's cape and other design elements were changed. Luna's clinic also had the lake dry up and rise, changing even its shape. Casshern and the others were the same, but Ouji's truck had decayed into an art object.

"This, a hat? Why?" asked the director.

"Umakoshi-kun said 'In the end it's definitely the hat!'" said I.

A conversation while looking at the suddenly submitted character design. Yes, Braiking Boss's hat. He'd been saying this for quite a while. The director said "Hmm. I see" and approved it.

And naturally the colours matched the original work. But I hadn't properly watched the original. I hurriedly did image searches on the Internet (burst). That's how I decided it.

The first scene I decided for episode 24 was Boss and Casshern's one-on-one battle scene. Colours with weight that still brought out proper colour tones. I decided this core scene's balance first, then worked backwards to decide each previous scene.

Next I decided Lyuze's final scene. "Ouji in evening, Lyuze in morning" - before discussing death scenes, both the director and I separately thought this way, and particularly for Lyuze we both thought "not sharply vivid, but a somewhat hazy morning," which is how it turned out. In episode 24, to show the "near death feeling," I deliberately drained saturation from Lyuze's complexion to make it whitish. My initial idea for the sequence of Lyuze breathing her last in Casshern's arms was to leave only the main lines and make everything white, with just the "C" on Casshern's chest red, but it felt too excessive so I scrapped it (laughs).

The other scenes were built up individually following the *Casshern Sins* worldview we'd established.

The colour idea for the final "Luna's hall" came from the director. Initially I had tried making it reddish monochrome, but during director checking he said "You can put in some weird colour. Like light blue?" That's how that scene was completed. It fit that scene so perfectly it was shocking (laughs).

And the ending.

This was also decided quite early to be "with Yukie-san's art" and "still images like the opening." And I would do the colouring. But with this terrifying schedule, I had no time to handle colouring myself. So I had Akimoto-san, who was helping with the final episode, handle all the colouring.

I thought grown-up Ringo should wear a cream-coloured dress, but I forgot to convey that. But telepathy? Wonderful! She properly coloured it with a cream-coloured dress! So the ending is mostly Akimoto-san's colours as-is.

Atmosphere-wise it was set several decades after the main story ended, so actually Friender had become quite an old dog. I was preparing to properly show that old dog depiction in the ending, but amazingly that ending cut got dropped (laughs). Poor Friender, loyally unlucky until the very end...

This final episode 24 was actually a bit unsatisfactory. We couldn't broadcast with the screens everyone was trying to create and deliver. *Casshern Sins* is a TV work, and normally what was broadcast on TV should be the completed, final form, but our abilities were insufficient and it aired in an "incomplete" form. I shouldn't make excuses here, but episodes 22-24 in the DVD version have been touched up a bit to become the visuals we originally aimed for.

Though unsatisfactory, please watch on DVD or Blu-Ray once more if possible.

Anyway, *Casshern Sins* is complete. It feels like a big typhoon passed, the sky is clear beautiful weather, the mood is refreshing, but now we have to clean up the scattered house debris - that kind of feeling.

But you know, this feeling is wonderful. So once again, without learning my lesson, I want to create works together with Director Yamauchi.

(09.03.31)